

Adeptus Custodes — 'The Better Thing 2' Runbook

Version 1.0 · 2026-07-28

Mindset

Play it as an elite tempo-and-attrition army, not a slow brick. Its game: take the priority objectives early with the fast pieces (Venatari/Vertus + Sisters), delete whatever contests them in melee (marked target + Ka'tah stance + the Allarus hammer), and out-last everything on 2+/4++. Three disciplines: (1) TARGET with the buffs — Assemblage-mark and stance each turn on the thing that decides it, don't spread; (2) TIME the Allarus — ingress T1 to pressure or hold them to answer a threat, and re-roll the charge; (3) don't get out-actioned — use the Sisters/Vertus for secondaries so the bricks are free to fight. Accept the one bad matchup (a true horde out-bodies you) and grind everyone else on quality.

Tapestry quick-reference

Rule	What it does
Martial Ka'tah — the ARMY rule (Sustained OR Lethal, MELEE only)	FIGHT PHASE only. Each time a Custodes unit is selected to fight it picks the BEST stance for that target: DACATARAI ([SUSTAINED HITS 1]) or RENDAX ([LETHAL HITS]). Crossover (with Martial Mastery's crit-on-5+): the two are equal when you wound on 4+ (S=T); default to SUSTAINED, flip to LETHAL only when target Toughness > weapon Strength (wounding on 5+/6+). For the S7 Guardian spears: SUSTAINED vs T7 and below (most infantry/light vehicles), LETHAL vs T8+ (Knights, heavy vehicles, big monsters). Army-wide on every unit with this ability; Shield Host stacks on top.
Shield Host — Assemblage of Might (mark -> +1 wound)	Command phase: mark ONE enemy unit. Until your next Command phase, each model in an ADEPTUS CUSTODES CHARACTER unit gets +1 to WOUND vs it. Per Core Rule 19.01 an attached unit is a single unit for all rules purposes and gains CHARACTER, so this covers the WHOLE led brick (all 5 spears of Valerian+Wardens / Blade-Champion+Guard / Shield-Captain+Guard) AND any solo character — NOT the standalone Allarus (no attached leader = not a Character unit; they still get crit-5 + a stance + Slayers). Point the mark at the durable thing you must crack and the bricks wound it on a much better roll.
Shield Host — Martial Mastery (crit-on-5+ / +1 AP)	Start of the battle round, pick ONE (army-wide until next round): (a) unmodified melee Hit of 5+ scores a CRITICAL HIT, or (b) +1 AP to all melee. Option (a) is the engine — crit-on-5+ roughly DOUBLES the Ka'tah proc rate: with RENDAX every 5+ auto-wounds ([Lethal]), with DACATARAI every 5+ throws an extra hit ([Sustained]). The Shield-Captain's MASTER OF THE STANCES then gives HIS unit BOTH stances for one fight (Sustained AND Lethal at once). NOTE: applies to every model with the Martial Ka'tah ability — so the Allarus benefit from crit-5 + stance too.
Tharanatoi Hammerblow — the deep-strike Allarus hammer	THE HAMMER FALLS: an ADEPTUS CUSTODES TERMINATOR unit that made an INGRESS MOVE this turn re-rolls charges. This list takes NO enhancements (no Mnemo-Locked Shrine Cipher), so the 5 Allarus arrive from Reserves (T2+) or via the core RAPID INGRESS stratagem at the end of the opponent's Movement phase — and re-roll the ~9"

charge on the turn they ingress. SLAYERS OF TYRANTS (re-roll Wounds vs CHARACTER/MONSTER/VEHICLE) makes them a precision anti-elite/anti-tank delete; HARDENED RESOLVE (+1 T, 1CP) makes them a T8 rock; ELECTROEXORCIST SATURATION turns the Balistus launchers into D3+3 A anti-horde; UNLEASH THE LIONS splits them into 5 single-model action/board pieces.

Durability — the whole army is a rock

2+/4++ on EVERY model (T6 W3 Guard/Wardens, T7 W4/W5 Allarus/Vertus). Valerian's Golden Laurels (-1 AP to melee vs his unit) + Wardens' Feel No Pain + Resolute Will (-1 to wound vs S>T) make the anchor near-unkillable. AP-heavy shooting is blunted by the 4++; volume struggles against 2+. You out-LAST almost everything.

Speed + board control (the un-Custodes part)

M10 Venatari + M12 Vertus (Turbo +6") + deep-strike Allarus = a fast, flexible board game most Custodes lists lack. The jetbikes/jet-packs grab and flip objectives, the Vertus Quicksilver Execution drops mortals over a screen, and the Sisters of Silence (Prosecutors) do the cheap ACTIONS/secondaries a low-model army usually can't.

Sisters of Silence — anti-Psyker + cheap bodies

Prosecutors (2x) + Witchseekers give an elite army the CHEAP OC bodies + action-doers it normally can't afford, and the Sisters are ANTI-PSYKER (shut down enemy psychic + Witchseeker Torrent flamers auto-hit hordes). A clean answer to Thousand Sons/Grey Knights/psychic decks and a screen vs everyone.

The Emperor's Champions of the meta — kill priority

You have no shortage of quality; the discipline is TARGETING. Assemblage-mark the thing you MUST kill each turn; Ka'tah-stance to match (Lethal vs high-T, Sustained vs many/durable); send the Allarus into the enemy's biggest CHARACTER/MONSTER/VEHICLE (Slayers re-rolls wounds); Blade Champion Precisions an attached buff-character. Do NOT waste the Warden brick chasing chaff.

What genuinely beats it

(1) A TRUE HORDE (Orks) — ~40 elite models can't out-body ~100 and physically can't cover the board, so you get out-scored on primary even while winning every fight; (2) being out-ACTIONED by an evasive objective army if your bricks get bogged in the wrong fight. It has no bad DAMAGE or DURABILITY matchups — only a body-count / tempo ceiling.

Per-matchup battle plans

Emperor's Children — 52% (Coin-flip) · you play **Vital Link** vs **their Purge the Foe (they play Destroyer's Wrath)**

Deciding factor: You out-fight the melee swarm outright: 2+/4++ + FNP eats the Infractor/Daemonette attacks, Rendax-Lethal spears + Assemblage delete units, and the Allarus (Slayers re-roll vs VEHICLE) one-round the Defilers. Their AP-1/-2 volume is the wrong shape for your armour.

- Mark + Allarus a Defiler each turn (their only real anti-armour); Slayers of Tyrants deletes it.
- Rendax (Lethal) or Dacatarai (Sustained) on the spear bricks vs the swarm; let the chaff break on the Warden anchor.
- Blade Champion Precisions a Lord Exultant; grind primary — they can't out-durable or out-score you.

Watch: Fulgrim (Fights First) trading into a brick — mark him + Master-of-the-Stances the fight, or receive on the FNP Wardens.

Orks — 36% (Unfavourable) · you play **Secure Asset vs their Take and Hold (they play Inescapable Dominion)**

Deciding factor: The one army that beats quality with QUANTITY: ~100 Boyz out-body your ~40 models on primary, and even winning every fight you can't clear the tide or cover the board. Your spears + Witchseeker flamers + grenades mow Boyz, but you get out-scored while doing it.

- Dacatarai (Sustained) + Witchseeker flamers (Torrent, auto-hit) + Allarus grenades (D3+3) to maximise Boyz-per-turn.
- Hold your objectives with the 2+/4++ bricks (Boyz can't shift them); use Venatari/Vertus to contest flanks + flip.
- Race secondaries with the Sisters/jetbikes; accept you won't out-primary a full horde — minimise the margin.

Watch: Getting tar-pitted + out-actioned; ~40% is real. Klaws/big-mek stuff can chip even 2+/4++ over 5 turns.

Adeptus Mechanicus — 60% (Lean favourable) · you play **Sabotage vs their Priority Assets (they play Sabotage)**

Deciding factor: Their D6-damage guns over-kill your W3 bodies (waste) and the 4++ blunts the rest, while you're FASTER than they expect (Venatari/Vertus + Allarus deep-strike close the gap turn 1-2) and delete the gunline in melee. Mark + Ka'tah shreds Kataphrons.

- Ingress the Allarus + rush the jetbikes T1-2; Slayers re-roll wounds crush the Kataphron/Kastelan bricks.
- Mark the biggest gun brick; Lethal/Sustained spears finish it; hold objectives their static line can't contest.
- Sisters screen the deep-strike lanes; out-score once their shooting is tar-pitted in melee.

Watch: Culexus/assassins sniping Valerian/Shield-Captain (throttles the buffs) — screen the characters with bricks.

T'au Empire — 34% (Unfavourable) · you play **Vital Link vs their Purge the Foe (they play Destroyer's Wrath)**

Deciding factor: Their rail/fusion (AP-4/-5) ignores armour, but you're on a 4++ + Wardens FNP + Valerian's -1 AP + Resolute Will, and you're FAST enough to be in their face turn 2 (jetbikes + Allarus ingress). Once you close, T'au fold in melee. Survive the alpha, delete the suits.

- Reserve the Allarus + hide the anchor from first-turn rail LoS; jetbikes + Venatari pressure T1.
- Mark a Riptide/Crisis brick; Allarus (Slayers vs MONSTER) + spears delete it; Hardened Resolve (+1T) tanks the return.
- Kill markerlight Pathfinders to cut their hit-buffs; hold objectives + out-score the low-body Cadre.

Watch: Devastating-Wounds rail spikes bypassing the 4++; spread the bricks + don't clump into one fusion volley.

Necrons — 57% (Lean favourable) · you play **Secure Asset vs their Take and Hold (they play Inescapable Dominion)**

Deciding factor: C'tan durability (4++/-1Dmg/reanim) blunts even your output, and they out-OC with reanimating bodies. Your edge: Allarus (Slayers re-roll vs MONSTER) + marked Lethal spears chip a C'tan, and you out-fight Wraiths/Lychguard. A grind you steal on objectives, not a blowout.

- Mark + focus ONE C'tan (Allarus + a spear brick); spread chip just reanimates away.
- Blade Champion Precisions a Technomancer/Cryptek (cuts reanimation); Wardens hold the middle.
- Win on primary + secondaries with the fast pieces; it's a grind you can steal.

Watch: Reanimation refunding your damage + their forced-battle-shock tech; focus-remove whole units.

Adeptus Custodes — 66% (Favourable) · you play **Secure Asset** vs their **Take and Hold (they play Inescapable Dominion)**

Deciding factor: A golden mirror decided on the margins: who marks + stances better, who wins the Allarus exchange, and who plays the objectives with the fast pieces. Both sides are 2+/4++ walls, so it comes down to Ka'tah discipline (Lethal to crack 2+/4++), the Blade Champion character duel, and tempo.

- Rendax (Lethal Hits) is king in the mirror — auto-wounds skip the tough-to-wound roll into their 2+/4++.
- Win the Allarus fight (Slayers vs their CHARACTERS) + Blade Champion duels their character (Precision).
- Out-tempo with Venatari/Vertus on objectives; the mirror is a coin-flip you tilt with better targeting.

Watch: Their Master-of-the-Stances / Assemblage timing — mirror the buffs and don't over-commit a brick.

Blood Angels — 78% (Favourable) · you play **Secure Asset** vs their **Take and Hold (they play Inescapable Dominion)**

Deciding factor: A glass melee alpha into a 2+/4++/FNP wall is your matchup: DC/Sang Guard hit hard on the charge but bounce off your armour, and you RECEIVE and delete them (Ka'tah + Assemblage) or counter-charge with the Allarus. They fold once the alpha's spent; you don't.

- Screen so the jump units land 9"+ out; receive the charge on the FNP Wardens (Living Fortress if needed).
- Mark the DC; Lethal spears + Allarus delete the spent alpha; Blade Champion Precisions Lemartes/a Priest.
- Out-grind + out-score — you're the durable one, they're the glass one.

Watch: Overwhelming a single brick with a full DC+character charge before you stance up; spread + mark first.

Dark Angels — 57% (Lean favourable) · you play **Sabotage** vs their **Priority Assets (they play Sabotage)**

Deciding factor: Terminator mirror where you edge on OUTPUT + speed: RENDAX (Lethal) auto-wounds skip the roll into their 4++/-1Dmg mace brick, your Allarus (Slayers vs their CHARACTERS) delete the support, and you're faster (jetbikes) to the objectives. Both durable -> decided on the mission.

- Rendax-Lethal + Assemblage-mark the Deathwing brick; auto-wounds beat the 4++ better than to-wound rolls.
- Allarus + Blade Champion hunt the Inner Circle characters / the Lion (a Monster -> Slayers re-rolls).
- Out-tempo on objectives with the fast pieces; grind the mirror on primary.

Watch: The mace brick out-grinding a lone Warden unit; commit with the Allarus + stance, don't feed piecemeal.

Drukhari — 77% (Favourable) · you play **Vanguard Operation** vs their **Reconnaissance (they play Search and Scour)**

Deciding factor: Rare for Custodes: you MATCH their speed (M10-12 jetbikes/jet-packs) AND tank their splinter (2+/4++, and poison/lance is the wrong shape for T6/T7 quality), then delete their paper. They can't kite what keeps pace, and they fold when they commit.

- Jetbikes/Venatari keep pace + contest the board; Interception... no — Vertus + Allarus one-shot Ravagers/Venoms.
- Mark + Ka'tah delete the Incubi/Wyches when they commit; hold objectives so they can't just flip late.

- Screen with Sisters vs backfield raids; out-score the paper on quality.

Watch: Getting out-actioned by their raw speed if you sit still — YOU have the speed here, so use it, don't castle.

Astra Militarum — 62% (Favourable) · you play **Sabotage** vs their **Priority Assets (they play Sabotage)**

Deciding factor: Their big guns over-kill your W3 bodies (waste) and the 4++ + FNP blunt the rest, while you're fast enough to close and the Allarus (Slayers re-roll vs VEHICLE) + marked spears delete a superheavy in melee. Their infantry can't out-fight yours.

- Ingress the Allarus onto a Russ/Shadowsword (Slayers vs VEHICLE) + mark it; delete a tank a turn.
- Rush the jetbikes into the gunline; carve the Guard infantry with Sustained spears; hold objectives.
- Out-body their low-model tank list on primary + secondaries.

Watch: Artillery + Leontus orders chipping the bricks before you connect; screen + close fast.

The list

Unit (count)	×	Role / rules	Pts
Valerian + Custodian Wardens (5)	6	WARLORD brick. Valerian: 2+/4++/FNP6+, Golden Laurels (melee AP into his unit worsened -1), Hero of Lion's Gate (change a roll to a 6, once/battle). Wardens: 2+/4+++, Feel No Pain (Living Fortress once/battle), Resolute Will (-1 to wound vs S>T while led). The unkillable anchor.	360
Blade Champion + Custodian Guard (4)	5	Blade Champion: Vaultswords S7 AP-2 D2 A6 [PRECISION] -> character-assassin; Swift Onslaught (re-roll charges) + Martial Inspiration (advance+charge). Guard: Battleline 2+/4+++, S7 AP-2 D2 A5 spears.	280
Shield-Captain + Custodian Guard (5)	6	Shield-Captain: MASTER OF THE STANCES (once/battle, BOTH Ka'tah stances active for a fight = Sustained AND Lethal). Guard: Battleline, +Praesidium Shield (a 4+ FNP body) + Vexilla (+OC / anti-deep-strike).	325
Allarus Custodians (5)	5	THE HAMMER (standalone unit — NO attached leader, so not a Character unit: gets crit-5 + a Ka'tah stance + Slayers, but NOT the Assemblage mark). Terminators 2+/4++ T7 W4, Guardian spears + Balistus grenade launchers. Deep Strike from Reserves (T2+) or RAPID INGRESS at end of opp's Move; The Hammer Falls re-rolls charges on a turn they ingressed. Slayers of Tyrants (re-roll Wounds vs CHARACTER/MONSTER/VEHICLE = anti-elite/anti-tank); Hardened Resolve strat (+1 T); Electroexorcist Saturation strat (Balistus -> D3+3 A vs hordes); From Golden Light = redeploy once. (No enhancements taken, so no T1 ingress.)	275
Venatari Custodians (3)	3	FAST (M10 jet-pack). Venatari lance S4 AP-1 D2 A2 [ASSAULT] -> mobile objective-grabber / chip; can drop from reserve. (x2 in the list.)	165
Venatari Custodians (3)	3	2nd fast jet-pack unit — board control + late-objective flex.	165
Vertus Praetors (2)	2	FAST jetbikes (M12, Turbo Boost +6"). Interceptor lance S7 AP-2 D2 A5 [LANCE] (charge threat) + hurricane bolters (S4 AP-1 D2 A3 [RF3, Twin]). Quicksilver Execution = mortal-wound bomb over a unit. (x2.)	145
Vertus Praetors	2	2nd jetbike unit — fast objective + anti-infantry + the mortal bomb.	145

(2)

Prosecutors (4)	4	Sisters of Silence: cheap boltgun bodies for SECONDARIES / ACTIONS / screening. (x2 in the list.)	45
Prosecutors (4)	4	2nd cheap action/objective unit.	45
Witchseekers (4)	4	Sisters of Silence: Witchseeker flamers S4 AP0 D1 A(D6) [IGNORES COVER, TORRENT] -> auto-hit anti-horde + ANTI-PSYKER (Sisters shut down enemy Psykers). Board-clearer / screen.	50